

CT-268 PROFESSIONAL ETHICS

LECTURE 3

MORAL REASONING & ETHICAL DILEMMA



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WHAT IS MORAL REASONING?

- **Moral reasoning** is the mental process of coming to some decision of right or wrong in any **moral** dilemma.
- **Moral reasoning** is a systematic approach to making **ethical** decisions.
- So how does one go about addressing an actual moral problem?
 - Ethical evaluations do have a role in devising responses to ethical problems.



EXAMPLE

- Suppose my manager tells me to dispose of some regulated toxic substance by dumping it down the drain. In this case, part of my problem is that what I have been ordered to do is potentially injurious to human health and illegal.
- In this case, the question is what can and should I do?
 - It is not enough to say that I should not dump the waste down the drain. My problem is not the simple choice of answering yes or no to the question of whether I should follow the order.
 - I need to figure out what to do about the supervisor's order.
 - Ignore it?
 - Refuse it?
 - Report it to someone? To whom could I report it? Someone else in the company?
 - Follow another course of action altogether?
 - Is there any place I can go for advice about my options in a situation like this? How or where can I find out about the likely consequences of each course of action?
 - What do I do with that toxic waste, at least for the time being?



DOING JUSTICE TO MORAL PROBLEMS

- Any answer to the question of what to do will depend on a variety of factors.
 - Learning what factors to consider and how to assess them are components of responsible professional behavior.
- The need for a response in the form of action is what makes ethical problems, practical problems.
- People confronted with ethical problems must do more than simply decide whether to perform some particular act.
 - They must do more than evaluate alternatives; they must devise possible responses; they must formulate a plan of action.



- Practical problems may or may not have solutions.
- Of those practical problems that are ethically significant – which are what we have been calling “ethical problems” – some call for coping rather than for solution.
- For example, a system of drainage ditches might be designed to prevent damage from periodic flooding of a river.
 - The design would count as a solution to the problem of how to cope with periodic flooding,
 - although the ditch system would not prevent the floods and would not solve the problem of flooding itself.



- For ethical problems, there is no *uniquely* correct solution or response.
- Experience shows that responses to challenging ethical problems are not obvious, however.
 - That is what makes an ethical problem challenging.
- Part of what ethics education is about is increasing the store of good responses that people can readily think of in the face of a moral problem.



ETHICAL DILEMMA

- An ethical dilemma is a situation where you must choose between two or more conflicting moral rules, and every choice results in breaking an ethical principle.
- An ethical dilemma in professional ethics is a situation where a worker must choose between two or more competing moral obligations, where taking one path means violating another.
- Unlike a simple right-versus-wrong choice, both options carry negative consequences or compromise a core value.



COMMON ETHICAL DILEMMAS

- **Truth versus Loyalty:** Choosing between telling the truth or being loyal to a friend, family member, or coworker.
- **Individual versus Community:** Weighing the needs, health, or rights of a single person against the greater good of society.
- **Short-term versus Long-term:** Deciding whether to act for immediate gain or sustainable future benefit.
- **Justice versus Mercy:** Balancing fair, strict adherence to rules and laws versus showing compassion or granting an exception.
- **Conflict of Interest:** Navigating a situation where personal interests, financial gain, or overlapping roles clash with professional duties.



- The initial problem about the toxic waste is an interesting ethical problem with several acceptable responses.
 - It may be possible to change the manager's mind, perhaps by detailing the potential health effects or the legal liability to the company, or by simply stating that in conscience, one cannot dump the waste.
 - If the manager is adamant, it may be possible to get others in the company – the ethics or environmental office, if any, or the legal department, if any – to countermand his/her order.
 - The character of one's organization makes a difference to one's response as well.
 - There may be several ways of properly disposing of the waste while not embarrassing the company or coworkers more than necessary.



FOUR LESSONS

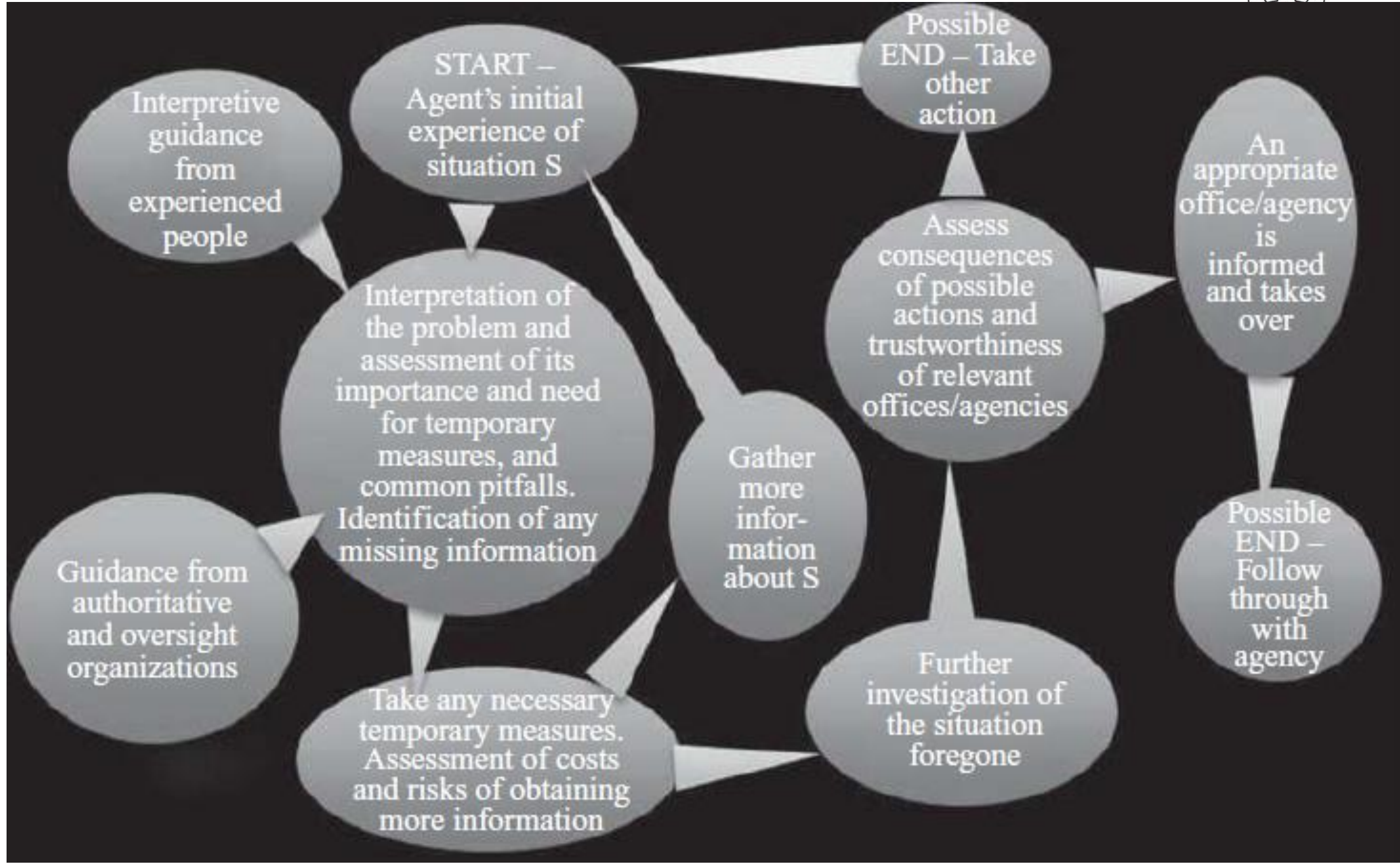
- Four moral lessons can be drawn from ethical design problems.
- The first lesson is to begin by considering the unknowns, ambiguities, and uncertainties in the situation.
- The second lesson is that the development of possible solutions is distinct from definition of the problem, and may require more information.
- A third lesson concerns acting under time pressure.
 - It is often important to begin by pursuing several possible solutions simultaneously, so that one will not be at a loss if one meets challenging obstacles, but also to avoid spreading one's energies too broadly.
- Fourth, the dynamic character of problem situations has further implications.
 - Both the problem situation and one's understanding of it are likely to change and develop over the course of time.



MAKING AND ASSESSING ETHICAL JUDGEMENTS

- Understanding, assessing, and making ethical judgments are a significant part of learning how to respond well to ethical problems.
- Considering the judgments of experienced individuals and authoritative organizations is a good way to discover:
 - What factors these individuals and organizations find most ethically significant.
 - What they think are the most likely realities underlying the apparent situation.
- It is also wise to discover the priorities of individuals and groups whose views are influential in the domain because those priorities will influence the reception your own actions receive.

STEPS IN RESPONDING TO AN ETHICALLY SIGNIFICANT PROBLEM SITUATION S





STEPS TO RESOLVE THE DILEMMA

- **Recognize the Conflict:** Name the specific moral duties that clash.
- **Identify Stakeholders:** List everyone affected by the choice.
- **Consult Codes and Laws:** Review industry guidelines and legal rules.
- **Evaluate Options:** Weigh outcomes using ethical principles like the greatest good or duty.
- **Decide and Reflect:** Choose the best path, document it, and evaluate the result.



WHAT WOULD YOU DO?

HONESTY VERSUS LOYALTY (PERSONAL LIFE)



- **The Situation:** Your close friend asks for your opinion on a major project they spent months creating. You see that the work is very poor.
- **The Conflict:** Honesty means telling the truth so your friend can learn and improve. Loyalty and kindness mean staying quiet to spare their feelings and protect the relationship. Whichever choice you make, you compromise an important value.



WHISTLEBLOWING (THE WORKPLACE)

- **The Situation:** You discover that your coworker and friend at the office is breaking a serious safety or financial rule.
- **The Conflict:** Duty to the company and fairness means you should report the violation. Loyalty to your friend means you want to protect them from getting fired or punished. Reporting them damages the friendship; hiding it breaks company rules.

PATIENT CONFIDENTIALITY VERSUS PUBLIC SAFETY (MEDICINE)



- **The Situation:** A patient tells a therapist or doctor they plan to hurt someone specific.
- **The Conflict:** Confidentiality requires medical professionals to keep patient secrets safe. Duty to protect requires warning the potential victim to prevent severe harm. Following one rule forces you to break the other.

PROFIT VERSUS ENVIRONMENTAL RESPONSIBILITY (BUSINESS)



- **The Situation:** A business leader finds a cheap way to manufacture a product, but the process pollutes a local water supply slightly more than the legal limit.
- **The Conflict:** Responsibility to shareholders dictates maximizing profit and lowering costs. Duty to the community and environment dictates protecting public health and nature. Choosing profit harms the environment; choosing environmental safety hurts company profit.





CRITICAL ETHICAL QUESTIONS

- These dilemmas prompt a range of critical ethical questions:
 - Who gets to decide what qualifies as a trade secret or a matter of national security?
 - What standards or rubrics are used to make these determinations, and are they consistent?
 - How can these decisions be independently audited or reviewed to prevent abuse?
 - Should there be time limits or periodic reviews for information classified as secret?
 - Would greater transparency reduce the need for whistleblowers, or are some secrets always inevitable?
 - How should the public interest be weighed against corporate or governmental interests in secrecy?
 - What safeguards exist to ensure that claims of secrecy are not used to cover up misconduct or avoid accountability?
 - Are there circumstances where the ethical imperative to disclose outweighs legal protections for secrecy?
 - How can stakeholders – including employees, citizens, and regulators – challenge or appeal secrecy claims?
 - What role should external watchdogs or independent panels play in overseeing decisions about secrecy?
- These questions highlight the ongoing need for robust debate and oversight to ensure that trade secrets and national security claims serve the public interest rather than merely protecting private or institutional power.

